

Shortest XOR Straight-Line Programs for 3×3 Matrix Multiplication: Benchmark Description

Greg Sidebottom Claude Fable 5

logic repository, <https://github.com/gsidebottom/logic>

Abstract—We contribute SAT instances deciding “do k XOR additions suffice?” for the output sides of rank-23 bilinear 3×3 matrix-multiplication schemes. Each boundary instance is a live mathematical question: an UNSAT answer at the right k lower-bounds the integer additive complexity of a scheme class and, combined with published exhaustive side analyses, would settle whether 55 additions are possible in known classes (current record: 56, Sun 2026). The family’s AND-guarded parity structure defeats current XOR/Gaussian reasoning while remaining genuinely hard for plain CDCL: no tested configuration (kissat, CaDiCaL, CryptoMiniSat plain and native-XOR, Z3 word-level, portfolios with symmetry breaking) decides the calibrated boundary cells within 10–30 minutes.

I. Problem origin

A bilinear scheme multiplying two 3×3 matrices with 23 products [8] evaluates 23 products of linear forms and combines them into the 9 output entries. Its additive complexity — binary $\pm$ additions in a straight-line program, negation free, no change of basis — has fallen rapidly: 60 [4], 59 [3], 58 [2], and the current record 56 [1]. Sun’s $56 = 13 + 13 + 30$ splits into two provably optimal input sides and an output side of 30 additions computing the 9 output forms from the 23 products.

Whether 55 additions are possible is open. An exhaustive orbit-level analysis of all 17,376 de Groote classes of the public Heule–Kauers–Seidl scheme database [5] (exact input-side minimization over every representative; research notes in the repository) reduces the question, for all known classes, to the output side: a 55-addition scheme in a known class requires an output side of ≤ 27 additions on specific representatives — two below the best output count ever observed at this format.

Any $\mathbb{Z}$ -coefficient output-side program reduces mod 2 to an XOR straight-line program, so the decision problem

SLP(k): do k XOR additions suffice to compute the 9 given output forms (vectors in $\text{GF}(2)^{23}$) from the 23 inputs?

yields sound lower bounds: UNSAT at k proves the integer output side needs $\geq k+1$ additions, and UNSAT at $k = 27$ on the right cells (§III) closes entire equivalence classes for 55. These instances continue the tradition of matrix-multiplication benchmarks in past competitions [5], with a twist of independent solver interest: the parity constraints

are AND-guarded, which prevents CryptoMiniSat’s Gaussian elimination from engaging, while plain CDCL faces genuine parity hardness.

II. Encoding

SLP synthesis in the style of Fuhs–Schneider–Kamp [6], simplified by unit-vector inputs. For steps $t = 1, \dots, k$:

- Source selection. Step t selects exactly two sources among the 23 inputs and steps $1..t-1$ (sequential counter for the exactly-two constraint).
- Values. Value bits are parity-defined:

$$x_{t,i} = \text{sel}_{t,\text{base}_i} \oplus \bigoplus_{j < t} (\text{sel}_{t,\text{step}_j} \wedge x_{j,i}).$$

Unit-vector inputs make the base contribution a single literal. The AND-guarded parities are materialized as Tseitin chains (plain CNF) or native x-lines (CryptoMiniSat extension); the generator emits both.

- Outputs. Each of the 9 forms must equal some step value (selector-guarded bit equalities; weight-1 forms may match an input).
- Symmetry breaking (optional, default on): all step values nonzero; adjacent independent steps (step $t+1$ does not consume step t) must have strictly lexicographically increasing values. Sound: swapping adjacent independent steps preserves validity, so every program normalizes by bubble sort, and padding above the minimum survives as a dependent chain. Dead-step elimination is deliberately not used: with it, satisfiability is not monotone in k (odd-length padding can force a dead step), which corrupts minimum-finding by descent.

At $k = 29$ with symmetry breaking: 25,799 variables, 91,426 clauses.

III. Instances and empirical hardness

An instance is determined by (output tensor of a scheme representative, k). Tensors come from the public database and the record chain; the de Groote action makes the output form-set depend only on the pair (R, P) of $\text{GL}(3, 2)$ matrices; each of the $168 \times 168 = 28,224$ pairs is a cell (one concrete output-side instance), so every class supplies $\sim 28k$ cells — a practically unlimited supply, with k the hardness dial:

- SAT phase ($k \geq \text{minimum}$): minutes at minimum + 1; witnesses are extracted and replay-verified by the generator.
- Deep UNSAT (k well below minimum): easy.
- Boundary ($k \in \{\min - 1, \min\}$): hard. On the calibrated seed cells no tested configuration decides the boundary within 10–30 minutes (Apple M4 Pro, one core per solver): kissat (600s and 1800s), CaDiCaL (600s), CryptoMiniSat 5 (615s, plain and native-XOR), Z3 4.16 on a word-level QF_BV formulation (600s), and a kissat+CaDiCaL+CMS portfolio with symmetry breaking (900s).

- [7] J. Boyar, R. Peralta. A new combinational logic minimization technique with applications to cryptology. SEA 2010.
- [8] J. Laderman. A noncommutative algorithm for multiplying 3×3 matrices using 23 multiplications. Bull. AMS 82(1), 1976.

TABLE I
Calibrated seed cells (SAT witnesses verified).

cell	weight	GF(2) min
sun56 output side (record scheme)	49	$\in \{29, 30\}$
cn120 output side ($C=28$ rep)	60	$\in \{27, 28\}$

Deciding either boundary advances the underlying question directly; UNSAT at 27 on the fat-sides window cells of the record class would, combined with the published exhaustions, make “no 55-addition scheme exists in the record class” a theorem with a DRAT certificate.

IV. Proposed benchmark set

Twenty instances spanning the phases: the two seed cells at $k \in \{\min - 1, \min, \min + 1\}$; the identity cells of the two other known 56-addition classes (i12w219c23ci, i19w225c4efh) at their boundaries; and four fat-sides window cells of the record class at $k = 27$; each with and without symmetry breaking. All are emitted by the C-side lower-bound generator (cxl.py):

```
python3 matmul/cxl.py --bits SCHEME.bits \
--k K --dump out.cnf
python3 matmul/cxl.py --bits SCHEME.bits \
--k K --dump out.xnf # native XOR
```

(`--no-sb` disables symmetry breaking; all scheme bits files are committed in the repository.)

V. Availability

Generator, scheme inputs, verification tooling, and research notes: <https://github.com/gsidebottom/logic>. Submitted instances may be used freely under the competition’s standard terms.

References

- [1] Y. Sun. A 56-addition scheme for rank-23 3×3 matrix multiplication. arXiv:2604.27645, 2026.
- [2] D. Perminov. arXiv:2512.21980, 2025.
- [3] E. Mårtensson, P. Stankovski Wagner, J. Stapleton. arXiv:2601.05272, 2025.
- [4] J. Stapleton. arXiv:2508.03857, 2025.
- [5] M. J. H. Heule, M. Kauers, J. Seidl. Local search for fast matrix multiplication. SAT 2019; J. Symbolic Computation 104, 2021.
- [6] C. Fuhs, P. Schneider-Kamp. Synthesizing shortest linear straight-line programs over GF(2). SAT 2010.